

A FORCE FOR TRANSFORMATION

From laying the foundation of transparency through ICICI Lombard's listing to positioning it as a digital leader, Bhargav Dasgupta has spearheaded many changes

By **Teena Jain Kaushal**

► **IN SEPTEMBER 2023**, Bhargav Dasgupta stepped down from his role as CEO and MD at ICICI Lombard General Insurance Company after 14 long years. During that tenure, he achieved significant milestones that laid the foundation for increased transparency and accountability in the industry. Under his leadership, ICICI Lombard became the first general insurance company to be listed on the bourses in 2017.

"We are a listed company, very focussed on transparency and disclosure. The challenge was that most of our competitors were unlisted, and they didn't have the same demands on them in terms of disclosure and transparency. I strongly believe that companies should

list after 10 years because the discipline of listing is good for the industry," says Dasgupta.

For the insurance veteran, the listing was just one of the many highlights. His easy-going demeanour helped in the seamless merger of Bharti AXA General Insurance with ICICI Lombard, a feat accomplished swiftly after receiving final approval from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) in September 2021. After the merger, ICICI Lombard quickly rose to become the second-largest general insurer in terms of gross direct premium underwritten. By December 2023, it had captured an impressive 8.76% of the market, coming in second behind the state-owned The New India Assurance Co., which held 13.33% market share.

Dasgupta believes in hard work, and this is reflected in the numbers. Under his leadership, the gross premium of ICICI Lombard surged to more than ₹21,000 crore in FY23 from ₹3,457 crore in FY09, and profit after tax (PAT) grew 78 times during the same period—from ₹22 crore to ₹1,729 crore, a remarkable CAGR of 36.5%. Over the past three years, the company's premium earned (net) and net profit have grown at a CAGR of 16% and 13%, respectively. This performance has led to Dasgupta being crowned the winner in the Brokers, Mutual Funds & Insurance category of the BT-PwC India's Best CEOs ranking this year.

The 57-year-old management graduate from IIM Bangalore took charge of the insurer in 2009, but his association with the group dates back to 1992, when he joined what was then ICICI as a Senior General Manager. He held different positions within the group, including serving as Executive Director in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance. During his long tenure at ICICI Lombard, Dasgupta achieved remarkable success before stepping down on September 21, 2023, to explore an international career opportunity. At present, he is the Vice President (Market Solutions) of the Asian Development Bank in Manila.

Brokers, MFs & Insurance

BHARGAV DASGUPTA

FORMER CEO AND MD, ICICI LOMBARD GENERAL INSURANCE COMPANY

Gross premium written	FY23	21,771.8
	9MFY24	19,331
Profit before tax	FY23	2,112.5
	9MFY24	1,857.4
Profit after tax	FY23	1,729.1
	9MFY24	1,399.1
	FY23 RoE (%)	17.73
	Market Cap	80,694.8

● Data is on a standalone basis; all figures in ₹ crore except RoE; 9MFY24: April-December 2023

● M-cap as of February 23, 2024

● **Source** ACE Equity, BSE